

WHAT	WAS	NOW	HOW MANY	WHERE FROM	GOT
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Jumper / cardigan		☐
Shirts / polos		☐
Trousers / skirt		☐
Dress		☐
PE top		☐
PE shorts / joggers		☐
Socks / tights		☐
Coat		☐
School shoes		☐
PE trainers		☐
Wellingtons		☐
Book bag / rucksack		☐
Water bottle		☐
Lunchbox		☐
Swimming kit		☐

☐

The list, and the labelling.

Date

3/9

WHAT THE LETTER ASKED FOR Copy it here once

WHAT	HOW MANY	GOT	NAMED
		☐	☐
		☐	☐
		☐	☐
		☐	☐
		☐	☐
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Label the thing, not the bag

The bag comes home. The jumper does not. Everything that can be taken off during a school day needs a name on the item itself — jumper, coat, PE kit, water bottle, lunchbox, and **both shoes**, inside. It is an hour in August and it is the difference between losing four jumpers a year and losing none.

HOW YOU ARE LABELLING Pick one and buy enough of it

- ☐ Iron-on tapes — survive the wash, slow to do
- ☐ Stick-on labels — for bottles, boxes and pencil cases
- A laundry marker on the care label — free, and enough

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- ☐ Sew-on, if the school insists

Ordered on How many

LABELLED AND DONE

- ☐ Every jumper and cardigan
- ☐ The coat, inside the collar
- ☐ Both shoes, and both trainers
- ☐ Water bottle and lunchbox
- ☐ PE bag and everything in it

BUY TWO OF The things that vanish first

What the year actually costs.

Date4/9

LINE BY LINE ————— Guess first, then write what it really was

WHAT	RECKONED	REALLY	PAID
Uniform			☐
School shoes			☐
PE kit and trainers			☐
Coat			☐
Bag and lunchbox			☐
Stationery			☐
Books			☐
School dinners / snacks			☐
Clubs and lessons			☐
Trips			☐
Photographs			☐
Charity and dressing-up days			☐

It is never the uniform, it is the twelfth thing

Most people budget for the uniform and the shoes and stop there. The rest of the list above — trips, clubs, photographs, the dressing-up day in October — arrives in letters, one at a time, and is never added up. Total it in August and the letters stop being a surprise.

PAID MONTHLY, NOT ONCE ————— Dinners, clubs, the milk

WHAT	PER MONTH	SET UP
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

HELP THAT EXISTS AND IS NOT ADVERTISED Ask the...

- ☐ A uniform grant or voucher, if there is one
- ☐ Free or reduced school meals
- ☐ Help with trips and residentials
- ☐ Paying for a big trip in instalments

WHAT WE ARE NOT BUYING THIS YEAR —————

The week, on one page.

Date

5/9

Monday

Tuesday

Wednesday

Thursday

Friday

NEEDS

NEEDS

NEEDS

NEEDS

NEEDS

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COLLECTED BY

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COLLECTED BY

Print this one and put it where the bags are

PE kit on Tuesday, library book on Thursday, recorder on Friday, forest school wellingtons on the week you forget. None of it is hard to remember and all of it is impossible to remember at half past eight. This page lives by the front door, not in a folder.

The night before.

Date 7/9

A good morning is made the night before

Every difficult school morning is really an evening that did not happen. This page is meant to be printed once and used every night until nobody needs to read it — which takes about three weeks. Tick it for the first fortnight, then stop; by then it is a habit and the page has done its job.

THE EVENING, IN ORDER — Before anyone is tired, not after

- ☐ Bag emptied — letters, lunchbox, anything wet
- ☐ Tomorrow checked against the week on page 5
- ☐ Uniform out, all of it, including socks
- ☐ Shoes by the door, together
- ☐ Lunch made, or made as far as it will keep
- ☐ Bottle washed and filled
- ☐ Reading book and homework signed and in the bag
- ☐ Bag by the door, zipped

ANYTHING ELSE THAT IS ONLY YOURS —

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THE MORNING, SPLIT — Two columns so nobody does both

THE JOB	WHOSE	BY WHEN
Wake, curtains, lights on		
Breakfast		
Dressed		
Teeth and hair		
Shoes and coat		
Out of the door		

BEDTIME, WORKED BACK FROM WAKING —

Wakes at

So, asleep by

Which means upstairs at

FOR THE CHILD WHO IS SLOW IN THE MORNINGS —

- ☐ A clock they can read, in their room
- ☐ One instruction at a time, not a list
- ☐ Breakfast they can start without help
- ☐ Ten minutes earlier, rather than louder
- ☐ The same order every morning, so it stops needing to be said

The first day, and the first week.

Date 8/9

BEFORE

What they are looking forward to

What they are worried about

Who they already know in the class

What we said we would do about it

THE MORNING ITSELF

- ☐ Photograph at the door, before anyone cries
- ☐ Leave ten minutes earlier than you think
- ☐ Say what happens at the end of the day, out loud
- ☐ A short goodbye — long ones are harder
- ☐ Somewhere to go afterwards, for you

WHAT TO ASK AT PICK-UP — “How was school?” gets you nothing

- ☐ Who did you sit next to?
- ☐ What was the best bit of lunch?
- ☐ What made somebody laugh?
- ☐ What was hard?

The first fortnight is exhausting, and that is normal

Expect tiredness, short tempers and a child who falls apart at the door at four o’clock having been fine all day — that is what holding it together all day looks like from the outside. Early nights and a light week beat any conversation about it. If it is still hard after three or four weeks, that is when you talk to the teacher.

THE FIRST WEEK, DAY BY DAY

One line, that evening

DAY	HOW IT WENT
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Monday

Tuesday

Wednesday

Thursday

Friday

KEEP THIS WEEK LIGHT

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WORTH MENTIONING TO THE TEACHER

Names and numbers.

Date9/9

THE SCHOOL

Office

Absence line, and by what time

Class teacher

Teaching assistant

Head of year

Before / after-school club

School email or app

School nurse or first aid

OTHER GROWN-UPS WHO CAN COLLECT In writing, to the ...

WHO NUMBER TOLD

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PARENTS WORTH HAVING A NUMBER FOR

WHO, AND WHOSE PARENT NUMBER HAVE IT

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SEPTEMBER ADMIN, DONE ONCE

☐ Every form signed and sent back

☐ Medical and allergy details updated

☐ The payment app set up before you need it

☐ Emergency contacts checked, not assumed

☐ Term dates in your own calendar, all of them

NEXT AUGUST, THREE LINES Written now, worth ten next ...